Backyard Dig Turns Up Huge Viking Silver Treasure

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A homeowner in northern Denmark was clearing ground for a new **terrace**. Instead of just rocks and grass, the person found the largest silver **hoard** ever discovered in Denmark. It weighs more than 40 pounds.

After about half an hour of digging, a tool hit something strange. Hand digging turned up jewelry, coins, and silver bars. The finder called **museums** right away.

Archaeologists led by Torben Sarauw carefully dug the yard. They found about 700 silver objects. The treasure had been kept in a clay pot. The top broke long ago, so some pieces spilled into the soil.

The **hoard** includes silver bars, rings, and "**hack-silver**" bits Vikings used like coins. There are also English and Arabic coins and a tiny Thor's hammer charm. Experts think it was buried in the 10th century. Danish law says the treasure goes to the National **Museum**, and the finder gets a reward.

Word Treasure

hoard -- A hidden collection of valuable objects.

Archaeologists -- Scientists who dig carefully to study objects from the past.

hack-silver -- Small cut pieces of silver Vikings used like money.

terrace -- A flat outdoor space next to a house, like a patio.

museum -- A place that keeps and shows important historical objects.

Background you need

A hoard is a buried stash of valuable objects from long ago.

Vikings sometimes used cut pieces of silver like money.

In Denmark, big archaeological finds usually go to a national museum.

Break it down

WHO: A homeowner and archaeologists led by Torben Sarauw
WHAT: Discovery of a huge Viking Age silver hoard
WHERE: A backyard in northern Denmark
WHY: Digging for a terrace uncovered buried treasure from long ago

Why it matters

Everyday digging can uncover history that museums share with everyone, including kids.

Test what you remember

1. Where was the silver found?

(A) On a spaceship
(B) A backyard in northern Denmark
(C) In a bakery oven
(D) Under a school desk

2. About how heavy is the hoard?

(A) Two feathers
(B) A grain of sand
(C) One paper clip
(D) More than 40 pounds

3. About how many silver objects were found?

(A) Seventy thousand
(B) About 700
(C) Seven
(D) Two

4. What is hack-silver?

(A) A helmet
(B) A modern phone
(C) A boat
(D) Cut silver pieces used like money

5. Who keeps the treasure under Danish law?

(A) A candy store
(B) The National Museum of Denmark
(C) Only a neighbor
(D) A sports team

6. When do experts think it was buried?

(A) In the 10th century
(B) Last Tuesday only
(C) During a soccer match
(D) In the year 3000

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: D 3: B 4: D 5: B 6: A

Questions to think about

1. The finder: Called the dig the biggest surprise of a lifetime.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):